

Q How can I interact and play with my new baby? She's too young to do very much!

Your baby may seem to do nothing but eat and sleep in the first few weeks of life—she is very busy growing after all—but she is also primed for interaction and discovery. Play and stimulation are essential for your baby's development, helping her to learn about her world, about you, and how she fits in to this new place.

Early learning

You are your baby's first playmate—your play and responses guide your baby and give her the confidence to try new things. In the early months, your baby interacts with you and her surroundings in simple ways: looking, cooing and gurgling, making facial expressions, touching, and grasping. By providing stimulation appropriate to her age and stage, you enable your baby to practice and learn new skills that will take her forward

to the next stage of development. You can dedicate some one-on-one time to playing, maybe five minutes playing peekaboo, 10 minutes settling down to explore a book with fun textures, or a few moments showing her a new object or toy. Equally, much of your interaction will be woven into the fabric of your day: chatting during a diaper change, pointing out objects around the home, or spontaneously blowing a raspberry on her tummy as you dress her. Each interaction is intrinsically valuable.

Playmate and teacher Even small interactions, such as gazing into your baby's eyes, mimicking her facial expressions, and beaming back when she smiles, create new connections in her brain and increase her understanding of the world.

